

Chapter 29_2: I'm Sorry

Hearing these words, the smile that Ning Fuyi was still wearing stiffened for a moment.

Although Chu Qingqiu said she repeatedly saved her because of Ning Changfeng's entrustment, Ning Fuyi actually caught a hint of concern from her earlier words.

Chu Qingqiu, cared about her?

But Chu Qingqiu had never cared about her. In her previous life, she couldn't get close to Chu Qingqiu, and in this life, she couldn't even understand her.

In the previous life, Chu Qingqiu could have helped her up, could have protected her once. Even if she had just given her a smile or a word of comfort, she wouldn't have been so heartbroken, wouldn't have hated her so much. But there was nothing.

Chu Qingqiu seemed to have no emotions. She seemed unable to smile.

So Ning Fuyi laughed. She seemed unable to feel the pain, and said softly: "But what does it matter to the Divine Venerable whether my life is hurt or not?"

"After all, it's just an entrustment. The Divine Venerable has saved me several times, which is considered fulfilling it. Just be as indifferent to me as always, and others won't have anything to say about you." Ning Fuyi restrained the sudden sourness in her heart, making her words cold and her smile even brighter.

"The Divine Venerable is high above, the Divine Venerable will never know what it feels like to be stepped on and called worthless." Ning Fuyi spoke emotionlessly, satisfied to see Chu Qingqiu's face turn pale. "The Divine Venerable will never experience what it feels like to watch helplessly as the person you love dies, powerless to do anything."

"I'm going to Zhaoyao Mountain¹, I want to become stronger. Compared to these things, what does damage to my immortal meridians² and overusing my cultivation count as a price?" Ning Fuyi said as she turned her head away, still smiling, but with a hint of madness in her eyes. "I want all the people I love to live, I want those who hurt me to pay the price. In the Divine Venerable's eyes, are all these things wrong?"

"Ning Fuyi!" Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke. She was so angry that her shoulders were trembling. Ning Fuyi had never seen Chu Qingqiu this angry before.

The white jade staff in her hand suddenly reverted to its original form. At the same time, the Flying Feather Rope³ on Ning Fuyi's body disappeared. Ning Fuyi staggered to steady herself, one hand gripping her still-aching arm, half-leaning against a pillar.

"Get out." Chu Qingqiu suppressed her anger. Ning Fuyi didn't linger any longer, running down the pavilion without a word. Her light blue figure disappeared beyond the layers of palace courtyards.

The room suddenly became quiet. The little white tiger sat down pitifully and whimpered.

The dusk shadows fell on the person in the room. Chu Qingqiu stood in place for a very long time before sitting down on the couch.

Anger still remained, gazing into the void.

She had seen many versions of Ning Fuyi - confused, timid, pretending to be rebellious, indifferent, ruthless, and finally decisive in killing, indifferent to all living beings.

But it seemed only in that moment just now, when the child's eyes revealed sadness and grievance, yet smiled while calling herself worthless, was the real Ning Fuyi beneath all the masks.

The little white tiger huffed and suddenly jumped onto the bed, lying down beside Chu Qingqiu and resting its head on her leg.

"What should I do, Bai Lin⁴?" Chu Qingqiu spoke softly, her crystal fingernails stroking the fur on Bai Lin's forehead. "What should I do?"

Bai Lin made several whimpering sounds. Chu Qingqiu's fingernails stopped in mid-air.

"Really?" She lowered her eyes in a daze.

Ning Fuyi ran all the way out of Jingshan Palace⁵, past the increasingly dim paths and bridges, and stopped at the main gate of Zhuguang Pavilion⁶. She stood there panting, staring blankly at the three large characters of Zhuguang Pavilion.

She had angered Chu Qingqiu again. She should feel pleased.

But she couldn't describe what she was feeling right now. She seemed to have intentionally provoked Chu Qingqiu, but when those words came out, they also seemed to come from the heart.

Ning Fuyi suddenly lifted her sleeve to see a red mark on her delicate arm, her expression slowly returning to cold hardness.

These days, immersed in the current world, she had almost forgotten what kind of person she should be.

She shouldn't waste her energy on these matters.

The main gate of Zhuguang Pavilion creaked open. Ning Fuyi had already recovered her usual expression. She looked up and was embraced by Liu Wenzhu⁷ who rushed over. At the same time, she felt frantic collisions on her legs, so she said helplessly: "Ping'an⁸."

"Yiyi, thank goodness you're safe." Liu Wenzhu breathed a sigh of relief. She released Ning Fuyi and spun her around in a circle.

"When I came down from the arena, I saw Elder Pingyao⁹ carrying you away. I thought Li Chao'an¹⁰ had done something to you. Later I learned that you had defeated Li Chao'an." Liu Wenzhu spoke faster than ever before. "But Elder Pingyao said you suffered very serious internal injuries and nearly damaged your immortal meridians. Then they took you for treatment. I was worried, so I kept waiting at the door."

Liu Wenzhu covered her heart and said, "Don't make such arbitrary decisions in the future."

She and Rong Jin¹¹ had both heard that Ning Fuyi had used some technique they had never seen before, but they thought it might have been taught by Ning Changfeng. Afraid that asking too many questions might displease Ning Fuyi, they had agreed not to inquire in detail.

Ning Fuyi smiled. The warm feeling of being cared for rippled through her heart. She hummed in agreement and asked again: "The results of the competition..."

"Don't worry." Liu Wenzhu smiled. "The results are already out. You and I were both selected. However, I heard from Senior Brother Rong Jin that the elders and sect master argued for a long time about whether you had cheated. In the end, because it really couldn't be considered forbidden arts, they let it go."

"But the other disciples don't know about this. There might be some rumors tomorrow, so be prepared." Liu Wenzhu lowered her voice with concern.

"Don't worry." Ning Fuyi smiled. She had expected that the sect disciples would gossip, but she had heard enough gossip in the past to let it go in one ear and out the other.

The important thing was that she could go to Zhaoyao Mountain, and joy spread through her heart.

Liu Wenzhu had been waiting for a long time and had many things to tell Ning Fuyi. She didn't pull her back to rest but sent Ping'an back to the room. Then she linked arms with her and walked down the mountain, talking softly as they went.

"The elders and sect master discussed for a long time. I thought they would nullify the results, but unexpectedly, Divine Venerable Chu Ling¹² didn't agree to nullify them. Elder Pingyao, who is usually strict with you, also allowed you to go to Zhaoyao Mountain."

"But as long as you can go, that's good. And your injuries have healed now, so everyone's happy." Liu Wenzhu spoke while her hair swayed up and down, clearly showing her happiness.

Ning Fuyi's earlier gloom was also soothed by such joy, so she smiled with her while being amazed by her words.

She had thought that after waking up, she would still need to argue her case, but she didn't expect that Chu Qingqiu had already agreed, along with Elder Pingyao.

Things went so smoothly that she, who was used to obstacles everywhere, felt somewhat unaccustomed.

"Oh right, there's also Li Chao'an. You're really amazing, being able to beat her badly in the competition. She's still lying in bed crying now. It's really satisfying."

As they talked, the sky had completely darkened. Occasionally, a few disciples returning from the dining hall passed by, all looking at Ning Fuyi, but Liu Wenzhu glared them away.

"Hey, Fuyi, Wenzhu, why are you here?" They happened to encounter Rong Jin, who had just come out of the dining hall. He carried two jugs of wine in each hand and said in surprise, then smiled. "Perfect! Elder Yuanming¹³ gave me four jars of apricot flower wine¹⁴ brought from the mortal world. I was just looking for you."

"I know Yiyi likes this." He looked at Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi's heart moved, and she nodded at him too.

As soon as the cork was pulled out, the rich aroma spread out, mixing with the scent of peach blossoms, refreshing to the heart.

Just smelling it made Ning Fuyi feel drunk. She reached out to take a jar of wine, tilted her head back to pour it into her mouth. The mellow taste washed over her mouth, making her shiver comfortably.

It had been a long time since she had secretly drunk wine with good friends in a peach blossom grove. In those long years of the past, she had dreamed of such scenes more than once, waking up with tears soaking her clothes.

So now, being in such a scene again, there was mostly nostalgia and sentiment.

Her emotions were quite rich today. Ning Fuyi shook her head, chuckled, and drank several more sips until the wine went to her head before stopping.

"Drink slowly, Fuyi." Rong Jin also took a sip. "How long has it been since we drank like this? The last time was when the sect master was still here. Fuyi begged me to take her to steal wine to drink, and the next day she got so drunk that she fell into the pond."

"That got me a beating from the sect master." Rong Jin smiled, showing his white teeth, then quickly stopped smiling, his gaze turning to the moon hidden among the colorful peach blossoms.

"Yes, and she made me sweep the latrines for seven days." Ning Fuyi couldn't help but reminisce.

"Those were good times, with the sect master protecting us in everything." Rong Jin looked at Liu Wenzhu, then at Ning Fuyi, and put down the wine jar in his hand. "But Fuyi, even though the sect master is no longer here, Wenzhu and I are still here. If you have anything in the future, you must tell us first."

"I know what you're thinking. You want to make a name for yourself early, but no matter what, you can't use yourself as a wager. If the sect master's spirit in heaven saw this, she would be heartbroken for you."

Ning Fuyi's hand gripping the wine jar tightened.

"You want to go to the Zhaoyao Assembly¹. Even if I exhaust all methods, I will help you. But you don't cherish your own body like this - anyone who cares about you would feel heartache for you." Rong Jin sighed deeply and drank a few more sips of wine.

"Me too." Liu Wenzhu said softly.

Ning Fuyi listened to their words with lowered eyes, her heart filled with mixed feelings.

Indeed, she had been lonely for too long and had forgotten what it felt like to be protected. Now that she had tasted a little sweetness, she wanted to cry.

"I understand." She said softly, extending her hand to clink wine jars with them, then drained the remaining wine in one gulp.

The three chatted intermittently about their youth. As the moon rose above the treetops and they had drunk several rounds, they all became tipsy.

Liu Wenzhu had the worst alcohol tolerance and had long since fallen to the ground and entered dreamland. Rong Jin was better, but his face was also red, supporting himself drowsily.

Ning Fuyi still retained half her sobriety. She took the wine jar from Rong Jin's hands and put it down. Suddenly remembering something, she said softly: "By the way, thank you, Senior Brother, for sewing the sect robes. I've been wearing them for a day and really like them."

"Sect robes?" Rong Jin opened his bleary, intoxicated eyes and stared at Ning Fuyi's sleeves for a while. "Oh, this, this wasn't made by me. It was made by the Divine Venerable."

"The Divine Venerable, she, she wouldn't let me tell you."

Like a thunderbolt exploding, Ning Fuyi grabbed Rong Jin's sleeve and frowned: "Senior Brother, what did you just say? These clothes were made by the Divine Venerable?"

"Yes." Rong Jin shook his head and smiled. "The Divine Venerable, the Divine Venerable learned very well. A child can be taught."

After saying this, he lay back and fell asleep sprawled out.

Ning Fuyi stared blankly at the moon for a while, then suddenly stood up, walking out of the peach blossom grove with her intoxication. Her steps were quick, and soon she reached the outside of Jingshan Palace.

As usual, the barrier couldn't stop her, and there was no one to be seen in the palace. She followed the familiar path back to Chu Qingqiu's small building. As she climbed up, she heard the sound of a wine jar falling.

She quickened her pace a few steps. The door was wide open, and the rich wine aroma drifted through the door frame into her nostrils.

Under the gentle moonlight, a woman in a white dress sat by the window, her head leaning against the window frame, eyes closed, brow slightly furrowed.

The little white tiger was lying on its back under the table, apparently quite drunk as well.

Ning Fuyi shook her head, dispelling the blur in her eyes caused by drinking, and quietly stepped forward. When she reached Chu Qingqiu's side, she discovered that she was muttering something to herself.

So, as if possessed by a ghost, she leaned closer and heard the unclear words from her mouth.

It seemed to be a sentence that had been polished over and over again: "I'm sorry."

Footnotes

1. **Zhaoyao Assembly (招摇大会)** - A gathering or conference at Zhaoyao Mountain, likely an important cultivation event or competition.